

fossils are 1-2 in
(2.5-5 cm) in
diameter



The Jurassic Coast

A stretch of English coastline famed for its fossils of ancient, extinct animals and plants, as well as some striking natural landforms

Approximately 96 miles (154 km) long, the Jurassic Coast occupies part of two English counties, Dorset and Devon. The coast has attracted worldwide attention mainly because of the cliffs, composed of layers of sedimentary rock, that run along most of its length.

A walk through Earth's past

Overall, the rock layers of the Jurassic Coast contain a near-complete record of Earth's Triassic, Jurassic, and Cretaceous periods. At different stages during this vast timespan, the area where the coastline now extends has been a desert, a tropical sea, an ancient forest, and a lush swamp. All these times and environments have been recorded in different rock layers. The area's significance in palaeontology only began to be realized in the early 19th century. In 1811, a local fossil collector, Mary Anning, and her brother discovered the complete fossil

of a large, extinct marine reptile called an ichthyosaur. Subsequently, she made more discoveries, including fossils of a pterosaur (an extinct flying reptile). This helped trigger an explosion of interest in the area's fossil legacy, which has continued to the present. Some of the more recent discoveries here include fossils of extinct crustaceans, insects, and amphibians, and a fossil forest of ancient conifers and tree-ferns.

In addition to its interest to paleontologists, the Jurassic Coast contains some superb examples of various types of natural landforms, including sea arches, rock pinnacles, and an enormously long gravel bank.



marcasite crystal

◁ SHINY CLUSTER

Nodules of the gleaming mineral marcasite, a form of iron sulfide, are commonly found in rocks on the Jurassic Coast.

chalk groundmass

densely packed
fossils show that
animals lived in
great numbers



△ SECLUDED BANK

This remarkable gravel structure is Chesil Beach. It is 20 miles (30 km) long, and has the sea on one side and a lagoon on the other.

◁ NATURAL ARCH

Durdle Door is a limestone arch formed by wave erosion. The name Durdle comes from an Anglo-Saxon word *thirl* meaning "bore" or "drill."